

No dais to bias

Over the years, we've had many conversations and even arguments within the team about the way the world is testing and reviewing technology products. Not just how we review products, but also how you buy products.

Let's take mobile phones for instance, for which consumers used to have a budget in mind first and then would choose the best available phone for that price – OS and brand weren't the starting points of the quest. They were the decision you arrived at in the end, all things considered.

Today, there's a marked difference that we've noticed. Usually, the OS comes first, then the brand. So there's a fair share of people who will decide, "Definitely Android only, and preferably Samsung", and then start comparing. Someone else might decide on iOS (and thus Apple by default) or Windows or BlackBerry, or prefer Android and Sony, or HTC, etc.

Fanboyism has taken over now, and that fact is apparent from all the internet arguments you've no doubt come across (or participated in) already.

Now all this is fine. There's nothing wrong with passionately believing in something. Mankind's been doing it for thousands of years, and we call it religion. The problem only arises when people try and appear scientific about their beliefs. This is when confirmation bias and ownership bias take over, and we start believing that indeed the product we own is the best, and start looking for articles from so-called "experts" to support our claims. The people we're arguing with, however, seem to find just as many "experts" to support their claims as well. In the end, it just boils down to who shouts the loudest and for the longest...Not exactly the most scientific way of arriving at conclusions.

The Digit Test Centre has always been known for its process-driven methodology, and also for our constant drive to reduce individual subjectivity or bias by using rigorous test processes designed by the team as a whole. Many have argued that perhaps it's a little too cold a way to test, but I feel that's the way it should be.

Imagine a judge who'd never convict a good looking girl of a crime, no matter what the evidence. Would that be justice? Verdicts need to be cold to be fair. How can a reviewer/blogger/tech guru of your neighbourhood not be a little biased? All of them own a phone from some company or

another, bought with their hard-earned money – ownership bias. Some companies go out of their way to give their latest products to some bloggers and maintain a good relationship – conscious or subconscious bias comes in there as well.

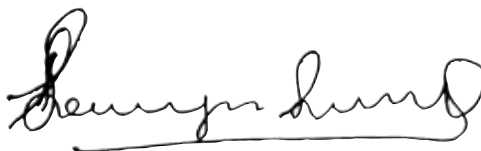
Take me, for instance. As a long-term BlackBerry user, I cannot deny having a soft corner for their devices. Are they the best devices out there, or the best priced? Certainly not! Yet I own one. When asked why I own this brand, I say because it's still the best for email, and work is priority for me on my phone. For fun and games, I have my Nexus 7 and iPad. The next argument thrown at me is "But BlackBerry has no apps", to which I usually respond that I have all the apps I really need. And the fact that I can download and install any signed APK from BBOS 10.2 onwards means I really can have almost all the apps I would ever need. For the life of me, I don't understand why BlackBerry doesn't advertise this more, but that's another story altogether.

However, is BlackBerry the best designed OS for mobile phones? I don't know. I'm not a fanboy (mildly biased, yes; fanatical, no), so I can't say with surety. Not without a rigorous test...

Thus, when the question dawned, "What's the best mobile phone OS?", began the current saga that has brought our little team to its knees with sleepless nights and thousands of features being double and triple-checked. You'll read more about it in the cover story itself, but take my word for it, this is the toughest and most comprehensive exercise we've ever done.

What's more, it's just part 1 of the saga and we'll next take on even more subjective biases and try to analyse those objectively as well. We will look at the actual UIs to decide what's easier to use and what isn't. We will also ask you for your feedback and criticism (and we expect a lot of that) to improve even further and arrive at a result truly devoid of bias of any sort.

Here's looking forward to reclaiming the ground that's been lost by logic, reason and actual testing to the fanatics and marketeers that sometimes disguise themselves as "experts", in order to con you out of your money. Just rest assured that at Digit, we give no dais to bias. Ever! 




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and let me know your thoughts.